

Data acquisition options for historical and upcoming NRL team lists and squad announcements

Executive summary

Primary, lowest-friction acquisition comes from the official NRL website's own structured payloads embedded in HTML. The draw and ladder pages expose JSON in `q-data` attributes (`#vue-draw` , `#vue-ladder`) that can be scraped without a headless browser, and those payloads include per-match match-centre URLs for downstream capture. ¹

Historical and upcoming team lists are best treated as “versioned documents”, not single facts. The official “Team Lists” topic hub provides a canonical stream of Tuesday team-list articles and game-day “Late Mail” updates, each with its own publish timestamp. ²

Terms matter. The official Terms of Use explicitly constrain use of NRL digital platforms to “personal, non-commercial use” and restrict reproduction without written consent, which is a practical trigger for licensing if your prediction system is commercial or redistributed. ³

For structured, ID-rich data (player IDs, team IDs, schedule IDs) and operational stability, commercial feeds (notably Stats Perform ⁴ as the league's official data partner) are the cleanest path. ⁵

A pragmatic build order is: (1) fixtures via `q-data` draw; (2) team-list URLs via the “Team Lists” topic page plus sitemap crawling; (3) parsing team-list articles into a normalised “named 17/extended squad + timestamp + source”; (4) monitoring and diffing for late changes; (5) only then add redundancy (club sites, media, community archives) and/or licensed feeds. ⁶

Official and primary English-language sources

Inventory table of official endpoints and pages

Effort scale: **S** (≤ 1 day), **M** (2–5 days), **L** (1–2 weeks), **XL** (multi-week, usually because of reverse-engineering or brittle JS).

Candidate source	URL / endpoint	Data fields typically available	Historical coverage	Access method
Team Lists hub (canonical discovery stream)	https://www.nrl.com/news/topic/team-lists/	Article list: title, section ("Team Lists"), publish date/time; includes links to team-list articles and "Late Mail" items	At least 2025–2026 are visible on page; back-crawl needed to confirm earliest available on hub	HTML (hub/listing page)
Team list article (Tuesday squads, round-specific)	Example: https://www.nrl.com/news/2025/08/05/nrl-team-lists-round-23/	Per match: home/away team names, player names, roles/positions and ordering; article timestamp; often includes links to casualty/judiciary extras	Confirmed for 2025–2026; use sitemap backfill to enumerate 2012–present availability	HTML scrape (article body markup)
Current season opener team list article (example of "special round" naming)	https://www.nrl.com/news/2026/02/24/nrl-team-lists-rugby-league-las-vegas-2026/	As above, plus special event context; still a structured team list article	2026 example	HTML scrape
Draw page with embedded JSON (q-data)	https://www.nrl.com/draw/?competition={comp}&round={round_number}&season={season}	Embedded JSON includes fixtures list with venue, city, home/away team objects (incl. nicknames, scores), kickoff time (clock.kickOffTimeLong), and matchCentreUrl per fixture	The endpoint is parameterised by season and round; validate back to 2012 by test crawl	HTML fetch + parse #vue-draw → q-data JSON
Ladder page with embedded JSON (q-data)	https://www.nrl.com/ladder/?competition={comp}&round={round_number}&season={season}	Embedded JSON includes ladder positions (team nickname) and stats (played, wins, losses, points for/against/diff, points, etc.)	Similar: parameterised by season and optional round; validate back to 2012 by test crawl	HTML fetch + parse #vue-ladder → q-data JSON

Candidate source	URL / endpoint	Data fields typically available	Historical coverage	Access method
Match-centre URL discovery (downstream fetch target)	Derived: <code>https://www.nr1.com{matchCentreUrl}</code> from draw <code>q-data</code>	Match centre URL per fixture enabling later extraction of final team confirmations or late changes (actual fields depend on match-centre payload/template)	Per-season	Derived from draw JSON
Clubs directory (official club-site registry)	<code>https://www.nr1.com/clubs/</code>	Official club site links (and club profile links). Useful for building your club-site seed list programmatically	Current	HTML scrape
Club site sitemaps (per-club URL discovery)	Examples: <code>https://www.parraeels.com.au/sitemap/current.xml.gz</code> , <code>https://www.warriors.kiwi/sitemap/current.xml.gz</code>	Sitemap URL lists for a club site, enabling discovery of team list posts and “late mail” equivalents hosted on that club domain	“Current” view; you’ll need historical sitemaps or archive crawling for older years	XML (gzipped)
Casualty Ward page (official injury UI)	<code>https://www.nr1.com/casualty-ward/</code> and filtered form like <code>https://www.nr1.com/casualty-ward/?competition=111&team=500023</code>	Intended UI fields: player name, team, injury, expected return; also links to injury news articles	Present; historic coverage unclear	JS-driven UI (HTML shows templated placeholders; data likely loaded via API)
Terms of Use (governs scraping and reuse)	<code>https://www.nr1.com/terms-of-use</code>	Key restrictions: personal/non-commercial use; limitations on reproduction/transmission; monitoring and access controls reserved to operator	Current page last updated 12 Dec 2017	Legal text page

Evidence for the `q-data` strategy is direct: fixture code in the `nr1R` package scrapes the draw page and reads `#vue-draw`’s `q-data` JSON (`fromJson(q-data)`), then uses `fixtures$matchCentreUrl` to build match-centre links. ⁷ Ladder extraction uses the same technique on `#vue-ladder`. ⁸

Evidence that team-list articles carry an internal timestamp is visible on official team list pages (e.g., "Timestamp Tue 22 Jul 2025, 03:59 PM"). ⁹

Competition IDs used by official NRL draw/ladder parameters

The draw/ladder endpoints use a `competition` query parameter. A practical mapping (used by `nr1R`) includes `111 -> NRL` and IDs for State of Origin and other comps. This is useful when you want to monitor multiple competitions consistently (NRL, NRLW, Origin). ¹⁰

Commercial and licensed feeds

Commercial feeds become attractive when you need (a) stable IDs across years, (b) guaranteed uptime and SLAs, (c) explicit rights to use the data in a product, and (d) richer metadata (team lists as structured objects, player IDs, injury status, late swaps) than you can reliably infer from web pages.

Inventory table of commercial/licensed options

Candidate source	URL / endpoint	Data fields typically available	Historical coverage	Access method	Reliability
Stats Perform ⁴ rugby league products (official partner positioning)	<code>https://www.statsperform.com/team-performance/rugby-league/</code>	Marketed coverage includes comprehensive match and performance data; live and post-game products; may include IDs and richer feeds depending on contract	Varies by contract	Commercial API/feed (JSON/XML)	High (commercial provider)
Official-data-provider announcements (context for procurement)	<code>https://www.statsperform.com/press/national-rugby-league-names-stats-official-data-provider/</code> and partnership messaging <code>https://www.statsperform.com/2024/07/stats-perform-celebrates-10-years-as-the-official-data-partner-of-the-nrl/</code>	Confirms official data partner relationship (useful for procurement justification)	2018 onward (announcement history)	Reference/material	High as contextual evidence

Candidate source	URL / endpoint	Data fields typically available	Historical coverage	Access method	Reliability
Stats Perform acquisition/contact guidance	https://www.statsperform.com/stats-perform-faqs-apis-and-data-delivery/	Explains delivery modes (APIs, feeds), formats (JSON/XML), and directs to sales for access/pricing	Current	Procurement guidance	High
STATS “Rugby League Web Service” (likely gated)	https://rugbyleague-api.stats.com/	Appears to describe endpoints (e.g., squads/players in season)	Unknown	Commercial API	Likely high if licensed
Champion Data ¹¹ match-centre JSON endpoints (publicly reachable, status unclear)	https://mc.championdata.com/data/competitions.json and https://mc.championdata.com/data/{comp}/fixture.json and https://mc.championdata.com/data/{comp}/{match_id}.json	competitions.json provides competition IDs; fixture.json provides per-match IDs and squads; per-match JSON includes matchStats with playerStats and playerInfo including playerId , names, and display names	Depends on what competitions and seasons are published under a comp id	JSON fetch	Medium-High technically, but operational legal risk if terms disallow
Sportradar ¹² Rugby League API	https://www.postman.com/sportradar-media-apis/sportradar-media-apis/collection/v6db9ub/sportradar-rugby-league-v3	Marketed: real-time scoring, match stats (when available), seasons/competitions/teams/players; push feeds for real-time plans	Varies by coverage tier	Commercial API	High

The most concrete, developer-friendly “structured” option you can start experimenting with immediately is the Champion Data JSON family of endpoints listed above, because they are straightforward JSON URLs and include [playerId](#) and fixture [matchId](#). Those exact endpoints and join logic are visible in the open-source [nr1R](#) code. ¹³

That said, the legal posture differs between “technically reachable” and “permitted to use”. The Terms of Use for the NRL web properties explicitly restrict use to personal, non-commercial use and restrict reproduction

without consent. Apply a similar caution to any third-party endpoints until you have explicit licence terms.

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Community tools and secondary fallback sources

Secondary sources are mainly valuable for redundancy (when an official page template breaks), gap-filling for older seasons, and cross-checking late changes when official sources lag.

Inventory table of community and fallback sources

Candidate source	URL / endpoint	Data fields typically available	Historical coverage	Access method	Reliability
nrlR codebase and package docs (documents working endpoints)	Code excerpts via <code>rdr.io</code> , e.g. draw parsing <code>https://rdr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_fixture.R</code>	Demonstrates how to scrape NRL draw/ladder <code>q-data</code> , and how to parse team list articles; also documents Champion Data JSON endpoints	Current package (published 2025)	Reference/code	High as a <i>reference</i> , not an official source
Rugby League Project ¹⁴ season/competition pages	<code>https://www.rugbyleagueproject.org/competitions/nrl/summary.html</code> and team index <code>https://www.rugbyleagueproject.org/competitions/nrl/teams.html</code>	Season summaries, teams, historical stats; site positions itself as an archive of historical results	Very broad (claims back to 1908 for history pages)	HTML scrape	Medium (community maintained) good for history, but not “official”
Fox Sports Australia ¹⁵ team-list coverage	Example: <code>https://www.foxsports.com.au/nrl/nrl-premiership/nrl-2025-round-1-team-lists-ins-and-outs-squads-eels-roosters-cowboys-debutants-cory-paix-broncos-michael-maguire-news-videos/news-story/3fa438ba9662fb7e6629c79d291a70f2</code>	Typically publishes full lists (1–17, extended bench) with commentary; timestamps	Multi-year	HTML scrape (often heavy scripts/ads)	Medium

Candidate source	URL / endpoint	Data fields typically available	Historical coverage	Access method	Reliability
The Roar ¹⁶ team-list tags	https://www.theroar.com.au/tag/nrl-team-lists/ and https://www.theroar.com.au/tag/nrl-team-list-tuesday/	Aggregated posts about team lists; often includes per-team lists embedded in article text	Multi-year	HTML scrape	Medium
Zero Tackle team lists	https://www.zerotackle.com/nrl/team-lists/	Round-by-round lists and updates	Current seasons emphasised	HTML scrape	Medium
LeagueUnlimited “Teamlist Tuesday” aggregation (timing reference)	https://leagueunlimited.com/news/leagueunlimited-nrl-teams-2025-round-18/	Text indicates the cadence (“from 4pm each Tuesday”) and presents compiled lists	Multi-year	HTML scrape	Medium
GitHub ¹⁷ repos documenting scraping practice	Example: https://github.com/beauhobba/NRL-Data	Shows Selenium/requests scraping patterns and a workflow structure (manual/weekly in README)	Project-specific	Reference/code	Medium

The `nrlR` fixture function is particularly valuable because it explicitly shows that <https://www.nrl.com/draw/> contains a `#vue-draw` node with a `q-data` JSON payload, which is the key to scraping without a headless browser. ⁷

The community archive site positions itself as “an archive of historical rugby league results” and provides competition summary pages and team indexes that can help validate team names and historical club identities. ¹⁸

Implementation guidance for data acquisition

Discovering historical team list URLs (2012–present)

Sitemap-driven enumeration is the most robust way to backfill 2012–present because it doesn't assume today's topic pages include older content.

NRL publishes a sitemap location in `robots.txt`, which gives you a stable starting point for URL discovery. ¹⁹

The sitemap index itself references multiple gzipped sitemap shards and a `current.xml.gz` feed (useful for incremental monitoring). ²⁰

A practical backfill strategy is to download each referenced `.xml.gz`, extract URLs, and filter by patterns like: - `/news/` AND (`team-lists` OR `late-mail`), for the official team list and late change articles. ²¹

For upcoming rounds, the “Team Lists” topic hub is your highest-signal feed for new team list pages and late mail entries. ²²

Scraping strategies for JS-driven pages

The single best tactic on NRL pages is to **avoid rendering** and instead **extract embedded JSON** when present.

Fixture and match-centre URL discovery can be done by reading the `q-data` attribute on `#vue-draw` from the draw endpoint: - `https://www.nrl.com/draw/?competition={comp}&round={round_number}&season={season}` - Parse `q-data` into JSON. - Read `fixtures[*].matchCentreUrl` to build match-centre URLs. ⁷

Ladder extraction works the same way via `#vue-ladder` and its `q-data`. ⁸

Team list articles themselves are scrape-friendly HTML pages. The `nrlR` implementation demonstrates a selector-based approach that identifies each game header (`match-header`) and then reads `li.team-list` items to extract home/away player names and roles. ²³

Some pages appear to be JS-driven without embedding `q-data` in the initial HTML. The Casualty Ward page shows templated placeholders and error messaging in the HTML served to non-JS clients, which strongly suggests the data is loaded from an API call at runtime. ²⁴

When a page behaves like Casualty Ward, there are three escalating options: 1. **Reverse-engineer JSON endpoints** by capturing network calls once (browser devtools) and then reproduce them with `requests` plus caching and headers. 2. Use a **headless browser** only for the “API discovery” step, then revert to direct JSON calls. 3. If the endpoint is private or volatile, fall back to scraping the linked injury-news articles, which are stable HTML pages. ²⁵

Entity resolution and IDs

Stable IDs are the main difference between “a scraper that works today” and “a dataset you can train on for 2012–present”.

If you consume the Champion Data JSONs, `playerId` is included alongside player names (`firstname`, `surname`, `displayName`), and fixtures provide `matchId`, `homeSquadId`, and `awaySquadId`. This is the fastest route to a consistent cross-season identity graph, assuming you have the rights to use the data.

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If you scrape team list articles, you should assume you'll initially see only names and roles. A robust resolution strategy is:

- Create a canonical `player` table with your own surrogate key.
- Attach multiple external identifiers when you have them (e.g., Champion Data `playerId`, NRL player-page slug, historical aliases).
- Maintain an alias table (`name_variant`, `from`, `to`, `effective_dates`) for spelling and diacritics (e.g., apostrophes). This is motivated by the fact that public sites mix display names and abbreviated forms.

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Timestamping, versioning, and change capture

Team list data is inherently versioned. Your storage should preserve:

- `source_url`
- `source_published_at` (from the article's timestamp where available)
- `scraped_at`
- `raw_html` (or raw JSON)
- `parsed_payload` (normalised roster object)
- `content_hash` and/or `diff_from_previous`

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Because NRL Terms of Use explicitly reserve the right to modify the network and content, and note that availability is not guaranteed, you should treat breakage as normal and engineer for easy reprocessing.

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Handling template drift

Template drift is easiest to manage if you test parsers against representative pages from different eras:

- modern round team lists (e.g., 2025 and 2026 examples),
- late mail pages from finals,
- and at least one older team list page once your sitemap backfill finds them.

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Unit-test the parsing logic, and keep a “known-good HTML fixture” corpus. The `nr1R` package itself includes tests for fixtures, ladders, and lineups, which is a useful pattern to emulate even if you write your own pipeline.

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Monitoring and automation blueprint for weekly capture

Ingestion and monitoring pipeline

```
flowchart LR
    A[Scheduler] --> B[Fetch draw q-data<br/>season/round/comp]
    B --> C[Extract fixtures + matchCentreUrl]
    C --> D[Discover team-list URLs<br/>Topic hub + sitemap deltas]
    D --> E[Fetch team-list articles]
```

```
E --> F[Parse to normalised roster model<br/>home/away, slot, jersey, role]
C --> G[Fetch match-centre pages<br/>(optional for final 17)]
G --> H[Parse lineups/confirmed teams<br/>(if extractable)]
F --> I[(Raw store: HTML/JSON snapshots)]
H --> I
I --> J[Versioning + diff engine<br/>hash, field-level changes]
J --> K[(Warehouse feature tables)]
J --> L[Alerting<br/>Slack/email/webhook]
```

Practical scheduling design for “Thursday/24h/final-17” inference

A match-centric schedule works better than a single weekly cron, because the round spans multiple days.

A minimal schedule is: - **Initial capture**: when the official team list article is published on Tuesday (widely reported as “Teamlist Tuesday”, commonly 4pm; use as a starting heuristic). ²⁸

- **Pre-match refresh**: run an automatic refetch and diff at a fixed offset (e.g., 24 hours pre kick-off per fixture), using the fixture kickoff time from draw `q-data`. ⁷

- **Final refresh**: refetch shortly before kick-off (e.g., 60–120 minutes) and on kick-off for a definitive snapshot. This is where match-centre parsing (if feasible) usually produces the cleanest “final 17” record, because it is aligned to the game object rather than a news article. ⁷

When official sources fail or lag, you can cross-check with secondary round aggregators (media or community), but treat them as non-authoritative and record provenance. ²⁹

Automation mechanics: diffing, webhooks, and polling

Diffing should operate on a canonical representation (e.g., `team_id`, `player_id`, `named_slot`, `status`) rather than raw text, so that formatting edits don’t look like roster changes.

For event propagation: - Convert “diff detected” into a webhook call to your model-inference service (or queue message). - Keep a human-readable “change log” for auditability (“Player X moved from 18th to 14; player Y omitted”).

If you adopt RSS/Atom feeds (where available), WebSub is a standard pattern to push updates rather than poll, but it depends on the publisher supporting it. ³⁰

Prioritised checklist of minimum viable sources and add-ons

A minimum viable, mostly-official pipeline can start without any headless browsing.

First build: - Pull fixtures and match-centre URLs from `https://www.nrl.com/draw/?competition={comp}&round={round}&season={season}` by extracting `#vue-draw` `q-data`. ⁷

- Pull team list URLs from `https://www.nrl.com/news/topic/team-lists/` and then scrape each team-list article into a structured roster snapshot. ³¹

- Backfill history by crawling NRL sitemaps (discover via `robots.txt` → sitemap index → gz shards) and filtering for `team-lists` and `late-mail` URL patterns. ³²

- Store snapshots with timestamps and diff them to detect changes. Use the article timestamp when present. ⁹

Then add-ons: - Pull official club-site domains from `https://www.nrl.com/clubs/`, then discover each club's team list announcements via their sitemap feeds (e.g., `/sitemap/current.xml.gz`). ³³

- Attempt match-centre parsing for "final 17" snapshots, using match-centre URLs derived from draw `q-data`. ⁷
- If you need injuries in a structured form, either reverse-engineer the Casualty Ward data calls (because the non-JS HTML doesn't expose the table) or rely on the linked injury news articles as a stable proxy. ²⁴
- If your use case is commercial or redistributed, move to licensed feeds (Stats Perform and/or Champion Data) to align with rights, stability, and consistent IDs. ³⁴

Risks to flag early: - Legal risk if you reuse or redistribute scraped NRL content outside "personal, non-commercial use". ³

- Breakage risk on JS-only pages (Casualty Ward) and on hub pagination mechanisms. ³⁵
- Entity-resolution risk if you rely only on player names without IDs across 2012-present. ¹³

¹ ⁷ `https://rdrr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_fixture.R`

`https://rdrr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_fixture.R`

² ⁶ ¹⁴ ²² ³¹ `https://www.nrl.com/news/topic/team-lists/`

`https://www.nrl.com/news/topic/team-lists/`

³ ⁴ ¹⁵ ¹⁶ ³⁴ `https://www.nrl.com/terms-of-use`

`https://www.nrl.com/terms-of-use`

⁵ `https://www.statsperform.com/resource/nrl-and-stats-perform/`

`https://www.statsperform.com/resource/nrl-and-stats-perform/`

⁸ ¹⁷ `https://rdrr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_ladder.R`

`https://rdrr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_ladder.R`

⁹ ¹¹ ²⁶ `https://www.nrl.com/news/2025/07/22/nrl-team-lists-round-21/`

`https://www.nrl.com/news/2025/07/22/nrl-team-lists-round-21/`

¹⁰ `https://rdrr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/helper-fetch-fixture.R`

`https://rdrr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/helper-fetch-fixture.R`

¹² ¹³ `https://rdrr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_player_stats.R`

`https://rdrr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_player_stats.R`

¹⁸ `https://www.rugbyleagueproject.org/`

`https://www.rugbyleagueproject.org/`

¹⁹ ³² `https://www.nrl.com/robots.txt`

`https://www.nrl.com/robots.txt`

²⁰ `https://www.nrl.com/sitemap/sitemap.xml`

`https://www.nrl.com/sitemap/sitemap.xml`

²¹ `https://www.nrl.com/news/2025/08/05/nrl-team-lists-round-23/`

`https://www.nrl.com/news/2025/08/05/nrl-team-lists-round-23/`

23 https://rdr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_lineup.R

https://rdr.io/cran/nrlR/src/R/fetch_lineup.R

24 25 35 <https://www.nrl.com/casualty-ward/>

<https://www.nrl.com/casualty-ward/>

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